Assignment 2: Data Storytelling Blog post

32558 Business Intelligence

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Tutorial 02

K-Drama Quality Over the Years: A Data Analysis of Ratings and Viewership from 2007 to 2024

Analysis of 100 Top-Rated Korean Dramas (2007–2024)

Data Source: https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/vitoriapontes/top-100-most-popular-k-dramas-at-january-2025/data

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Introduction

Korean dramas, also known as K-dramas has seen an increasing amount of popularity over the years. With the early K-drama origins from 1950's to the 2000's era of online streaming, and the present age of global streaming sites like Netflix, there has been international popularity of making the K-drama status as one of South Korea's most influential cultural exports (Dasgupta, 2026).

This blog analyses 100 most popular K-dramas as of January 2025, sourced from the publicly available 100 Most Popular K-Dramas/Korean Dramas at 2025 dataset on Kaggle (Pontes, 2025).

By analysing the ratings, viewership, and genre diversity across five different production eras, this blog addresses an interesting question relevant to broadcasters, streaming platforms, and viewers.

How have K-drama ratings and viewership changed over time, and which era produced the best content?

This analysis helps to understand which eras produced the most well-liked shows, what genres draw high viewership, and how the rise of streaming has an effect on them. The dataset provides the drama title, year, audience rating (out of 10), watchers count, airing schedule, genre, and number of episodes.

The Five Eras of K-Drama

To structure the analysis meaningfully, the 100 dramas are grouped into five chronological eras, each reflecting a distinct phase. Table 1 shows the different eras of K-dramas and their performance.

Table 1: K-Drama performance metrics by production era. Note. Source: Pontes (2025).

Era	Average Rating	Average Watchers	Number of Dramas	% Rated ≥8.8
Early Era (2007-2012)	7.9	105,888	7	0.0%
Growth Era (2013-2016)	8.4	134,275	29	17.2%
Peak Era (2017-2019)	8.3	124,321	26	11.5%
Streaming Era (2020-2022)	8.6	122,215	32	43.8%
Global Era (2023-2024)	8.7	95,935	6	66.7%

The Early Era (2007–2012)

In the early years from 2007 to 2012, most of the K-drama was romance genre. All seven dramas from this era have romance as a primary genre. Dramas such as Coffee Prince (2007, 8.3), Boys Over Flowers (2009, 7.5), and Secret Garden (2010, 8.2) established the style that would define the genre internationally, like charismatic leads, emotional storylines, and slow-burn romance.

As shown in Figure 1, average ratings during this period were around 7.93, the lowest of among the analysed eras, which suggests that the industry was producing good but predictable content rather than trying new creative ideas or risks.

However, viewership in this era was still high, with Boys Over Flowers attracting 169,953 viewers despite its 7.5 rating. This difference between reach and rating reflects an industry in its early phase, where audience size was driven by famous stars and a familiar romance genre rather than storytelling quality.

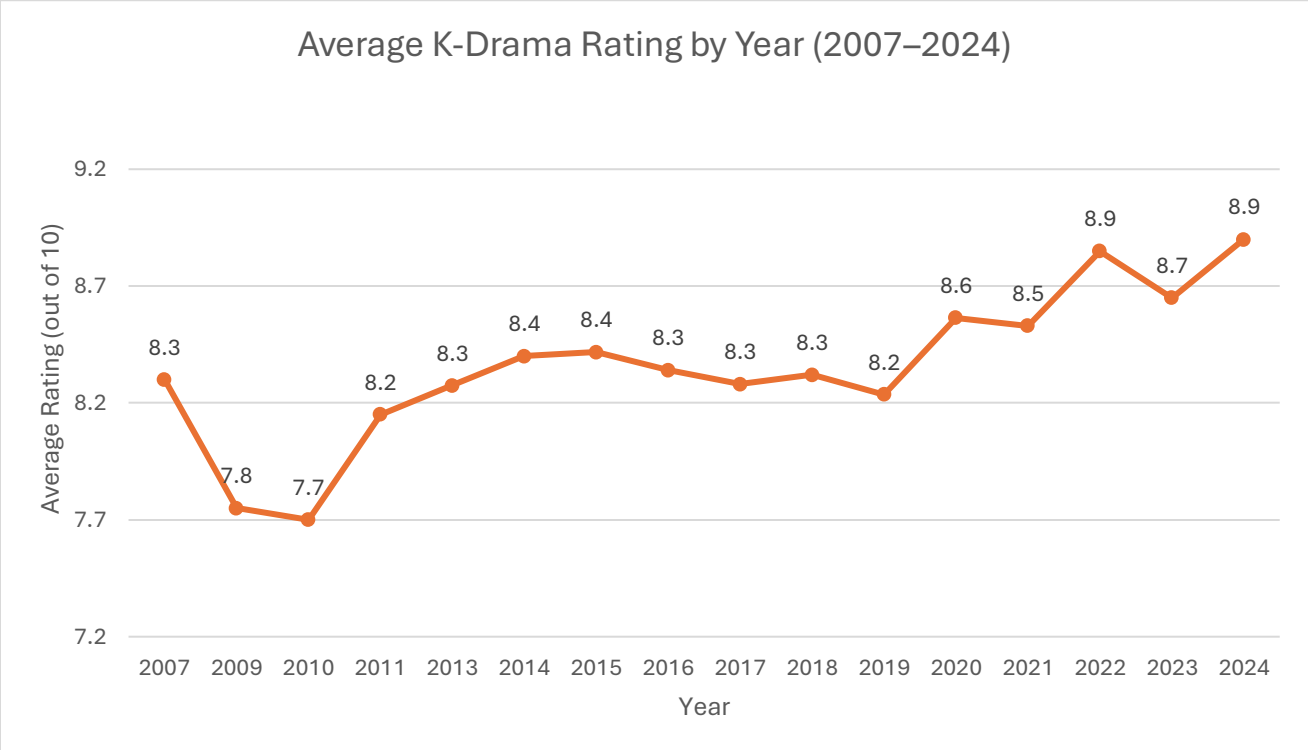


Figure 1: Average rating of top-rated K-dramas by year (2007–2024). Source: Pontes (2025).

The Growth Era (2013-2016)

The Growth Era has comparatively more dramas. In 2016 alone, there are fifteen dramas in the dataset which is greater than any other year. Broadcasters released lots of shows to meet the rising domestic and international interest in K-dramas. There was also a variety of Genres, with fantasy, thriller, and historical dramas appearing alongside romance. Goblin (2016, 8.8, 254,985 watchers) became the most-watched drama in the era and one of the most beloved K-dramas of all time. Signal (2016, 8.9) demonstrated that darker and more complex plots could compete with romance and be just as popular.

Figure 2 shows that the average rating went up from 7.93 in the Early Era to 8.36 in the Growth Era. This suggests that dramas are both improved in quality and also covered wider range of genres.

Average viewership was highest in this era, with 134,274 viewers per drama on average, the highest of any era in the dataset (Table 1). This suggests that releasing a large number of dramas successfully attracted large audiences, even if not every drama achieved high ratings.

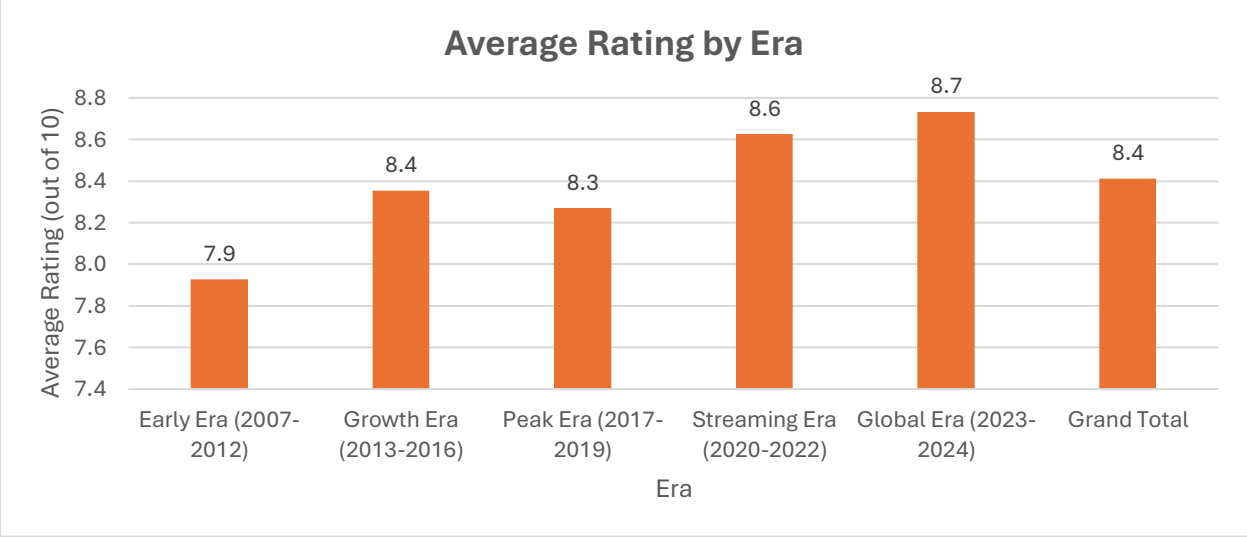


Figure 2: Average rating by K-drama era. Source: Pontes (2025).

The Peak and Streaming Eras (2017-2022)

A surprising finding appears in the Peak Era (2017–2019). Despite the release of famous dramas such as Crash Landing on You (9.0) and My Mister (9.0) in this era, the average rating went down a little to 8.27. The reason is that the number of dramas released during this era is high. 26 dramas across three years made it to the analysed top 100 list. This meant that lower-rated dramas like Love Alarm (7.1) and The Bride of Habaek (7.4) pulled the overall average down.

The Streaming Era (2020–2022) makes the change in data more obvious. This is when Netflix's investment in Korean original content brought larger budgets and creative freedom, producing the most consistently high-quality output of any era. Famous dramas like Flower of Evil (2020, 9.1), Hospital Playlist (2020, 9.1), and Alchemy of Souls (2022, 9.1) were all released during this era. As Figure 3 shows, the number of top-rated dramas remained consistently high from 2020 onwards, with 2020 contributing 14 titles to the dataset. Also, 43.8% of all Streaming Era dramas achieved a rating of 8.8 or higher (Table 1), which is nearly three times the rate of the Growth Era. The average rating increased to 8.63, which is the highest across all eras in the dataset.

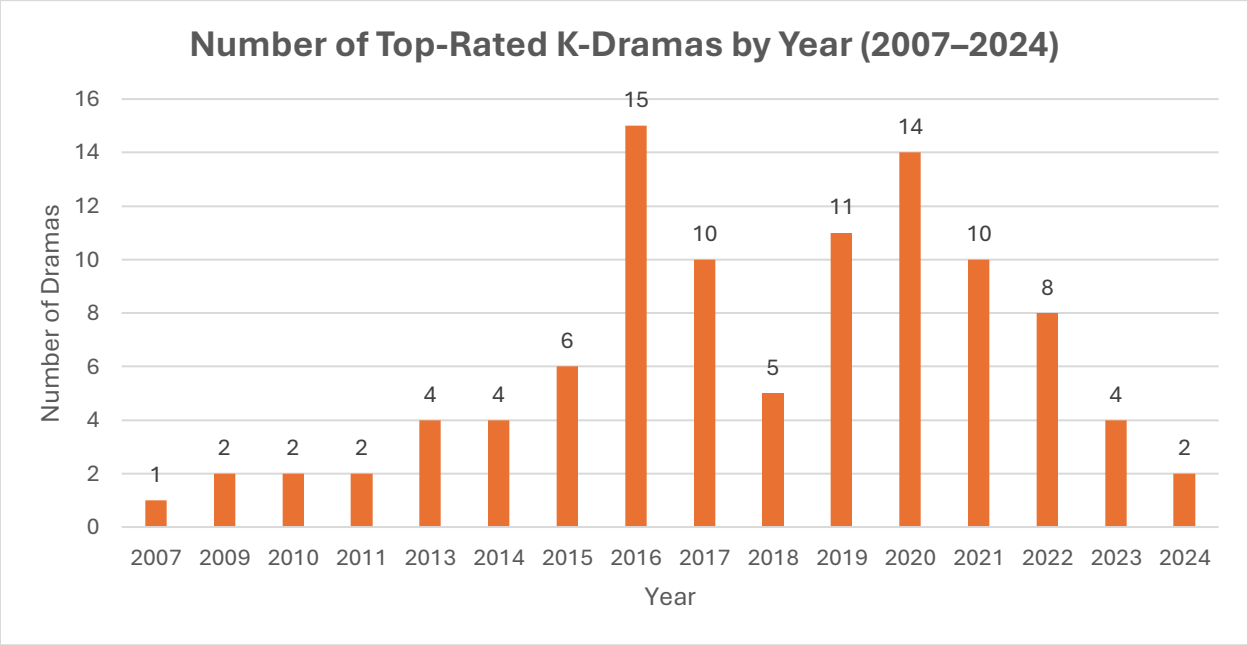


Figure 3: Number of dramas rated 8.8 or above by year. Source: Pontes (2025).

Discussion

Altogether, the data answers the research question clearly: K-dramas did get better over time, and the Streaming Era (2020–2022) made the best shows with the highest average rating (8.6) and the highest share of top-rated dramas (43.8%). The Global Era (2023-2024) continues this result with an average rating of 8.73, though this is based on only six titles and should be analysed more deeply.

There are three key findings.

1. Genre diversification improves quality: As dramas expanded beyond classic romance into thriller, fantasy, and psychological drama, average ratings improved over the eras.
2. Streaming platforms raised quality standards: Netflix's entry changed the economics of production, leading to tighter narratives and higher budgets.

3. High volume and high-quality dramas can coexist, but this requires careful management: the Growth Era shows that releasing more dramas increases viewership but creates mixed ratings. Figure 4 shows how the average number of watchers grew during this era.

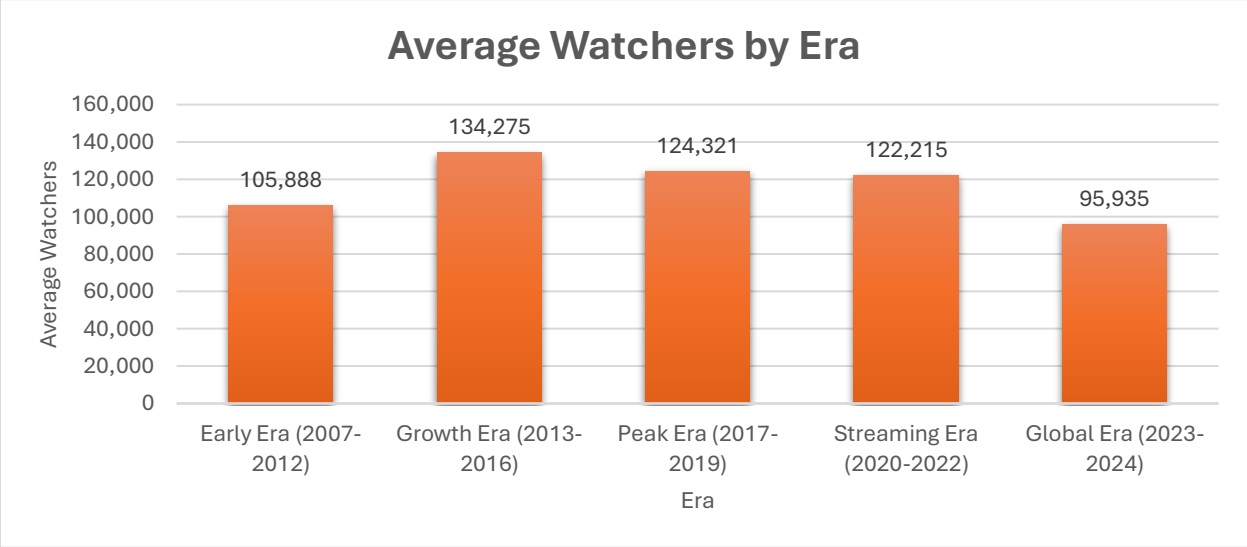


Figure 4: Average watcher count by K-drama era. Source: Pontes (2025).

Conclusion

This blog analysed 100 top-rated K-dramas from 2007 to 2024 and found that K-drama quality has improved significantly over time. Average ratings went up from 7.93 in the Early Era to 8.63 in the Streaming Era, and the share of top-rated dramas (rated 8.8 or higher) grew from 0% to 43.8%. The data shows that the Streaming Era (2020–2022) is the golden era of K-drama production, driven by Netflix investment and genre diversity.

So, the takeaway is that investing in diverse genres and limiting volume in favour of quality are strategies associated with the highest-rated output. The Global Era's results suggest K-dramas are still growing in popularity and quality.

References

Dasgupta, S. (2026). *Korean drama: Origin, features, notable people, popular series, and impact*. Encyclopaedia Britannica. https://www.britannica.com/art/Korean-drama

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